Checklist: Usability Testing

Introduction

Use this checklist to plan a simple moderated usability test. Observe how users complete realistic tasks without teaching or correcting them.

- ☐ Decide what page, feature, or task you want to test.
- ☐ Recruit people who resemble the intended users. Five participants is a useful starting point for one user group.
- ☐ Test the website or prototype before the session.
- ☐ Prepare consent, recording, notes, and accessibility needs.
- ☐ Tell participants: ‘We are testing the design, not you. There are no wrong answers.’
- ☐ Ask participants to think aloud while they work.

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Create Questions

Describe a believable situation and goal without telling participants which path to use. Follow each task with neutral questions.

- ☐ Give participants realistic goals, not step-by-step directions.
- ☐ Avoid using words from the interface that reveal the answer.
- ☐ Give one short, neutral task at a time.
- ☐ Ask the participant to read each task aloud before starting.
- ☐ Use neutral prompts such as ‘What would you normally do?’ or ‘Tell me more.’
- ☐ Test the questions with one person and revise anything unclear.

EXAMPLE QUESTIONS

- Your printer is showing “Error 5200.” How can you get rid of the error message?
- You’re considering opening a new credit card with Wells Fargo. Please visit wellsfargo.com and decide which credit card you might want to open, if any.
- Say you wanted to find the results of our team’s latest game. Walk me through how you would find this on the site.
- Step through the process of adding a sopapilla to your cart.
- What’s your opinion on how the information is laid out?
- How does this page or feature make you feel?

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Follow-Up Questions

Ask brief questions after each task, then end with an open discussion. Listen without defending or explaining the design.

- ☐ Ask how easy or difficult the task felt.
- ☐ Ask what the participant expected when something was confusing.
- ☐ Use the participant's own words; do not suggest an answer.
- ☐ Record task completion, errors, hesitation, and requests for help.
- ☐ Group repeated problems and decide which matter most.
- ☐ Turn the findings into specific changes to test next.

EXAMPLE POST-TEST QUESTIONS

- Overall, how easy or difficult was it to complete that task?
- What did you find most frustrating or confusing about the experience?
- What surprised you the most while navigating through this?
- If you could change one thing about this design or flow, what would it be?

Facilitator Reminders

- ☐ Talk less than the participant. Observe and listen.
- ☐ Do not lead, correct, teach, or react to success or failure.
- ☐ Thank the participant and explain how the feedback will be used.

Sources

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